

MODERN SEXUAL MORALITY AND MODERN NERVOUSNESS

By Sigmund Freud, M.D.

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BY

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INTRODUCTION

Whether one accepts Freud's teachings *in toto* or rejects a great part of them as unsubstantiated and untenable, one must admit that his influence on modern thought has been tremendous, incalculable—and *on the whole* beneficial. Many shams and hypocrisies have been uncovered and exploded by the ruthless analysis of modern psychology known as psychoanalysis, and in no field have the Freudian teachings borne better fruit than in the field of human sexology. That psychoanalysis has been exploited by charlatans and ignorant laymen for their own benefit and to the detriment of their victims is not to be laid at the door of its founder.

Of all Freud's writings—and their number is enormous—the writer considers the present essay the most important—the most

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important barring none. In this essay Freud clearly states his position on the importance of the sex instinct in modern civilization, on the relationship between sexual abstinence and nervousness or neurosis, and boldly proclaims, what medieval theologians still persist in denying, *that man's sexual instinct is not at all primarily meant to serve purposes of reproduction* but is intended to furnish certain forms of gratification.

It is because I consider Freud's essay on Modern Sex Morality and Nervousness epoch-making that I have made it available to the English reading public.

DR. W. J. ROBINSON.

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CAREFUL clinical observations justify us in dividing nervous morbid states into two groups, neuroses proper and psychoneuroses. In the former the disturbances (symptoms), whether they manifest themselves in physical or mental actions, seem to be of a toxic character. Their manifestations are quite similar to those which coincide with the excessive ingestion of certain nerve poisons.

These neuroses, generally designated by the term neurasthenia, can be produced by certain pernicious influences of the sexual life, without any hereditary taint as contributing factor; the aspect of the disease corresponds so closely to the nature of the pernicious element that caused it, that its clinical descrip-

tion often enough enables one to draw retrospective conclusions as to the particular sexual etiology.

On the other hand, we fail to observe such a regular connection between the aspect of the nervous disease and the other pernicious influences of civilization which authors have described as factors of disease. We may therefore consider the sexual factor as the real cause of neuroses proper.

In psychoneuroses, hereditary influences are more potent and actual causes cannot be determined as easily. A special method of investigation, psychoanalysis, has allowed us, however, to ascertain that the symptoms of those troubles (hysteria, compulsion neurosis, etc.,) are psychogenous and are traceable to the action of unconscious (repressed) imagination complexes.

Psychoanalysis has enabled us besides to study those unconscious complexes and to ascertain that generally speaking they have a sexual import. They originate in unsatisfied

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sexual needs and afford a sort of gratification in a different form. We must therefore, consider every factor which is harmful to the sexual life, which suppresses its activities or runs counter to its aims, as a pathogenic cause of psychoneuroses.

The value of the theoretical distinction between toxic and psychogenic neuroses is not diminished in the least by the fact that in the majority of nervous patients we observe disturbances traceable to both kinds of origin.

Those who believe as I do that the etiology of nervousness is to be sought above everything in pernicious influences which are brought to bear upon the sexual life, may be interested in reading the following pages in which I will attempt a comprehensive synthesis of the problem of the increase in nervousness.

Our civilization is entirely based upon the suppression of instincts. Every individual has had to abdicate a part of his property rights and to renounce in a certain measure the exer-

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cise of his power, to give up his aggressive and vindictive tendencies. The sum of those individual sacrifices constitutes civilization's common fund of material and mental riches. Not only the necessities but the family feelings derived from eroticism have led the individual to make such sacrifices.

Those sacrifices have been made gradually in the course of the evolution of civilization; every step in that direction was sanctioned by religion; whenever the gratification of an instinct was given up in part, that part was offered to the deity. Whatever advantages redounded to the community from that renunciation were declared holy. Whoever failed to carry out that suppression of his instincts, owing to his unbending disposition, was regarded by the community as a criminal, as an outlaw, unless his social prestige and his superior strength enabled him to impose himself as a great man, as a hero.

The sexual instinct, or accurately speaking, the sexual instincts (for analysis reveals that

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the sexual instinct consists of many elements, of many partial instincts) is undoubtedly more developed in man than in the majority of the higher animals; at any rate it is more constant in man for it has almost entirely outgrown the periodicity which characterizes it in animals. Owing to its peculiar capacity to change its object without losing any of its intensity it places great amounts of energy at the disposal of civilization. That faculty to exchange the original sexual object for another object, no longer sexual but psychic in nature, is known as the faculty of sublimation.

In contrast with the versatility of the sexual instinct wherein resides its cultural value, we observe in the sexual instinct also a stubborn fixity which makes it impossible to transvalue it entirely and leads to what we call abnormalities.

The original intensity of the sexual instinct must vary greatly in each individual; at any rate the proportion of it which lends

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itself to the process of sublimation is extremely variable.

We may well imagine that the person's organization determines in every individual case what part of the sexual instinct can be sublimated and transvaluated, and the influences of life and the intellectual influence of the psychic apparatus extend somewhat further the process of sublimation.

But the process cannot be carried on ad infinitum any more than the mechanical transformation of heat into energy. The majority of human organisms seem to require a certain amount of direct sexual gratification and the lack of that gratification, whose amount varies with every individual, brings forth manifestations which, on account of their functional harmfulness and of their subjective character of unpleasantness, we must consider as pathological.

Broad vistas open up for us when we bear in mind the fact that man's sexual instinct is not at all primarily meant to serve purposes

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of reproduction but is intended to furnish certain forms of gratification.

This is obvious in childhood when the instinct is gratified not only through the genitals but through many other parts of the body (erogenous zones) and therefore can do without other less convenient objects less easily attained. We call that stage the autoerotic stage and education is entrusted with the task of setting a limit to it, for should the instinct remain in that stage, it could neither be controlled nor transvaluated in later life.

The sexual instinct evolves then from autoerotism to love for a definite object and from the autonomy of the erogenous zones to their subjugation to the primacy of the genitals which are to assure procreation. In the course of that evolution one part of the sexual excitation derived from the individual's own body is checked as unutilizable and when circumstances are favorable submitted to a process of sublimation. Most of the energy that can be utilized for the tasks of civiliza-

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tion is derived from the suppression of the so-called perverse parts of the sexual excitation.

Bearing in mind this history of the evolution of the sexual instinct we may distinguish three stages: the first stage in which the activity of the sexual instinct extends far beyond the purposes of procreation; the second stage in which that part only of the sexual instinct is not repressed which serves the purposes of procreation; the third stage, finally, in which only *legitimate* procreation is countenanced as the aim of sexual activity. To this last stage corresponds the "civilized" sexual morality of the present day.

If we observe the second stage of civilization as our starting point we notice that a number of individuals are prevented by their own organism from satisfying the requirements of the morality corresponding to this stage.

In an entire series of individuals the above mentioned evolution of the sexual instinct

from autoerotism to love for an object and aiming at a union of the genitals has not been regular or complete and there results from those irregularities of development two harmful deviations from normal sexuality, that is from the sexuality demanded by civilization; those two deviations stand to each other in the relation of positive to negative.

Leaving aside the individuals with overdeveloped and uncontrollable sexual instincts, those deviations are responsible for the many varieties of perverts, in whom the fixation in infancy of a provisional sexual aim has prevented the primacy of the procreative function, and on the other hand, the homosexuals or inverts in whom the sexual aim has been, through some as yet unexplained process, deflected from the opposite sex.

If those irregularities of development are not as harmful as one would expect them to be, it is because the complexity of the sexual instinct eases up the process, allowing the sexual life to attain useful ends even when

one or more components of the instinct have developed along wrong lines. The constitution of the inverts or homosexuals often appears to be peculiarly adapted to the "civilized" sublimation of the sexual instinct.

The marked and even exclusive development of certain perversions and of homosexuality make the individuals affected by them socially useless and unhappy besides, so that even the cultural demands of the second stage must be recognized as a source of suffering for a certain part of mankind. The fate of the individuals who deviate constitutionally from the average differs according to whether they have a really strong or only a weak sexual instinct.

Perverts with a weak sexual instinct succeed in repressing the propensities which would bring them into conflict with the moral standards of their stage of civilization. But properly speaking this is about the only accomplishment of which they are capable, for the repression of their sexual instinct uses

up the energy which they could otherwise have turned to good use in "cultural" pursuits. They are inwardly self-repressed and outwardly paralyzed. We may apply to them what we will have to say of the men and women who practice abstinence in obedience to the demands of the *third* stage of civilization.

When the sexual instinct is more intense but perverted there are two possible outcomes: the first, which we do not intend to consider in this article is that the perverts remain perverts and have to bear the consequences of their deviation from the cultural standard. The second eventuality, by far the more interesting of the two, is that under the influences of education and the pressure of social demands, the perverted instincts are repressed; their repression, however, could be more accurately characterized as failure to repress them. The checked sexual instincts do not express themselves any longer as sexual instincts; that is the only thing gained, but

they crop up in other forms which are just as harmful for the individual and make him as useless for society as the direct gratification of his perverted instincts. This is wherein the process fails and this failure more than offsets the success achieved.

The substitute manifestations which crop up when the sexual instincts are repressed constitute what we designate as nervousness or more especially psychoneurosis. The neurotics are a class of people who, much against their own constitution and only yielding to the pressure of cultural standards, apparently succeed in repressing their instincts but fail more and more frequently in their undertaking as time goes on; it is only with a great expenditure of energy and at the cost of their inner impoverishment that they can continue to collaborate in the work of civilization; at times they drop out of the race laid low by illness.

If I have designated the neuroses as the negative phase of perversion it is because in

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neuroses the perverted tendencies, after being repressed, crop out of the psychic unconscious, because we find in neuroses the very same impulses which positive perverts betray, but in a repressed state.

Experience teaches us that there is, for the majority of men, a limit beyond which their constitution cannot comply any more with the "cultural" demands. Those who are trying to be better than their constitution permits them to be succumb to neuroses; *they would have been better off if it had been possible for them to be worse.*

Observations made among individuals of the same generation often confirm the hypothesis that perversion and neurosis stand towards each other in the relation of positive to negative.

It frequently happens that a brother is a sexual pervert, while his sister, who as a woman is endowed with a weaker sexual instinct, is a neurotic; her symptoms, however, betray the same tendencies as the perversions

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of her brother whose sexual activity is more intense. And this is why in so many families the men are perfectly healthy but immoral according to the usual social standards, while the women are very pure and super-refined . . . but terribly neurotic.

It is a crying social injustice that the cultural standard should exact from every one the same behavior in sexual matters; some people are so constituted that they can easily conform to it; others, on the contrary, are compelled to make the most painful psychological sacrifices; this injustice is rendered perfectly futile however by the fact that the majority of people disregard the precepts of "morality."

We have thus far based our comments upon the standards of the second cultural stage which places a ban on every so called perverted sexual activity but allows freely normal sexual intercourse. We find that even with the establishment of a boundary line between what is free and what is restricted, a

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certain number of individuals, the perverts, are left in a blind alley, while others who, in spite of their constitutional urge, are trying not to be perverts are driven into neuroses.

It is easy, therefore, to foresee the result which will be attained if we place new restrictions upon sexual freedom, raise the cultural standard to the level of the third stage and prohibit all sexual intercourse except in lawful wedlock. The number of strong individuals who will defy openly the cultural standards will increase enormously and so will the number of weak ones for whom the conflict between the pressure of cultural influences and the resistance of their constitution will have only one outcome: neurosis.

This leads us to discuss three relevant questions:

1. What duties does the cultural standard of the third stage place upon the individual?
2. Does the lawful sexual gratification it allows compensate the individual for the abstinence he has had to endure?

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3. To what extent do the harmful results of that abstinence offset the cultural advantages accruing from it?

To answer the first question we must touch upon a much mooted problem which we cannot attempt to solve here, that of sexual abstinence.

What the third cultural stage demands from the individual of either sex is abstinence before marriage, and lifelong abstinence for whoever cannot contract a legitimate union. The assumption fondly backed by all the authorities that sexual abstinence is neither harmful nor difficult to bear, receives also frequently the support of physicians. The task, however, of checking an urge as powerful as the sexual urge by other means than its natural gratification is one that consumes all the energy a man is capable of.

Checking it by sublimating it, that is by deflecting the sexual instinct from its sexual aim and towards loftier cultural aims, succeeds in a few cases, but only temporarily;

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to include women

the task is especially arduous in the fiery period of youth; in certain individuals attempts at sublimation provoke neuroses or other disorders.

Observation proves that the majority of people are constitutionally incapable of abstinence. Whoever suffers from moderate restrictions placed upon his sexual activity will chafe even more under the demands of our modern sexual morality; for sexual gratification is the only known protection nature affords to the normal sexual life against misdirected tendencies and irregular development. The more one is predisposed to neuroses, the less one can endure abstinence; the partial urges which deviated from the normal line of development have also become more uncontrollable.

But even individuals who would not have been harmed by complying with the demands of the second cultural stage are now driven in large numbers into neuroses. For the psychic desire for sexual gratification is en-

hanced by the mere fact that it is denied. The accumulated craving is now seeking an outlet through one of the weak spots in the structure of the sexual life, which is seldom free from such weak points, and then it breaks through and satisfies itself by means of some neurotic substitute in the shape of morbid symptoms.

Whoever fathoms the causes of nervous disorders soon comes to the conclusion that their increase at the present day is due to the greater and greater restrictions placed upon sexual activity.



We come now to the question whether sexual intercourse in lawful marriage does not compensate fully for the restrictions placed upon it before marriage. The amount of *negative* evidence at hand is so huge that we must make our arguments as brief as possible.

We must remember that our cultural sexual morality restricts even conjugal inter-

course, for it compels married people to procreate a limited number of children only. That consideration limits the period of satisfactory intercourse in marriage to only a few years from which must be deducted the various occasions on which the wife must be spared for hygienic reasons. After three, four or five years marriage no longer suffices to gratify the sexual needs; for all the means that have been thus far resorted to in order to prevent conception spoil the sexual enjoyment, disturb the finer sensibilities of man and woman or are the direct cause of illness. The fear of the consequences is fatal to the physical fondness of the mates, and later on to the mental fondness which should replace the stormy passion of the first embraces.

What with this moral disappointment and this physical privation, which is the rule in many families, man and wife find themselves exactly where they were before marriage, with the only difference that they have lost one more illusion and they must once more

exert their will power to control their sexual instincts and deflect them into other channels.

We need not go far to find out how adult man behaves in such cases; we know that he takes frequent advantage of the measure of freedom which even the severest sexual morality vouchsafes him, though secretly and grudgingly. The double standard which obtains in present day society is the frankest admission that society, much as it may issue decrees, does not believe that its decrees can be enforced.*

We also know that women who as the actual standard bearers of mankind's sexual life are only to a restricted extent able to sublimate their instincts, women for whom the child at the breast, but not the growing child, constitutes a compensation for sexual privation, suffer keenly from the disappointments of married life and contract incurable neuroses.

* This is not true of Anglo-Saxon countries. In these extra-marital intercourse is looked upon much more severely than in the Latin or Germanic countries.—*Editor*.

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Under the conditions of modern civilization marriage has ceased to be a panacea for woman's nervous ills; while we physicians will still advise marriage for cases of nervous disorders, we know very well that a girl must be very healthy to stand married life, and we advise strongly our male patients against marrying a girl of the nervous type.

We might say that the cure for the nervous troubles caused by marriage is conjugal infidelity; the more strictly a woman has been brought up and the more earnestly she has adapted herself to the cultural standards, the more repugnant that solution appears to her; the conflict between her desires and her feeling of duty drives her again to take refuge in a neurosis. For nothing protects her virtue as well as illness. The married state from which youth has expected the gratification of its sexual instincts cannot even satisfy the demands it creates; how could it offer any compensation for the period of abstinence which precedes it?

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One may admit all the harm done by the cultural sexual morality, and still answer our third question by claiming that the cultural gains redounding from the restrictions placed on sexual activity probably offset a form of suffering which only a small minority feels acutely. I confess I am unable to balance accurately such profit and loss accounts, but I could bring forth many points which would enable us to estimate fairly the actual losses.



Returning to the subject of abstinence which was barely touched upon in the foregoing pages, I may express my conviction that abstinence is the source of various ills *besides neuroses* and that in the majority of cases the importance of the neuroses has been minimized.

The retarding of sexual development and sexual activity which is the aim of our education and culture is certainly harmless. That retarding appears very necessary when we

consider the age at which young people of a cultured class begin to earn a livelihood and become financially independent. And here we are reminded of the intimate dovetailing of all the modern cultural institutions and of the difficulty we encounter when we attempt to modify one part of the social structure without taking thought of the rest.

Abstinence after the twentieth year is a difficult thing to achieve for a young man and when it does not cause nervous disorders it causes other troubles. We hear it said that the struggle against a strong instinct and the necessary cultivation of ethical and esthetic power in mental life steels one's character and is beneficial to certain natures with an especially fortunate turn; we must also concede that the differentiation of individual character which is such a marked feature of modern times is only rendered possible by the restriction of sexual activity. *In the great majority of cases, however, the struggle against sensuality consumes all of a young man's*

available energy at the precise moment when he needs it most so to win for himself a place in the social organism.

The proportion of possible sublimation and of unavoidable sexual activity varies considerably according not only to the individuals but to the careers they follow. Abstinence is hardly thinkable for young artists while young scientists who abstain are not a rarity. The abstinent scientist can devote more of his energy to his studies; sexual experiences, on the contrary, act as a stimulant to artistic activity.

My general impression is that sexual abstinence does not help to build up energetic, independent men of action, original thinkers, bold advocates of freedom and reform, but rather good weaklings who become merged later in the great mass which follow, though reluctantly, the impulses emanating from strong personalities.

The results of the efforts made to promote abstinence prove that the sexual instinct is,

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generally speaking, stubborn and impossible to curb. Our modern education only tries to repress it until marriage and intends to give it then a free rein and let it take care of itself. But extreme measures have more decided effects upon that instinct than mere attempts at moderating it; the process of repression often goes too far and it happens that the sexual instinct after being given a free rein is found to be permanently damaged.

Complete abstinence is not therefore the best preparation for matrimony for a young man. Women seem to feel this and prefer to be wooed by men who have demonstrated their virility with other women.

One can realize readily the functional disturbances which are provoked in woman by premarital abstinence. Modern education assumes in great earnest the task of repressing a girl's sensuality until the time when she marries and it often resorts to the severest means. Not only does it place an ab-

solute ban upon sexual intercourse, and offer many inducements to the woman who retains her sexual innocence but it also protects the female against temptation by keeping her in ignorance of the details of her future vocation and removes all the sensual stimuli which do not lead to marriage.

The result is that when parental authority allows a girl to bestow her love on a man, she fails to respond psychically and she enters the matrimonial state with a good deal of uncertainty as to her own feelings. The artificial retarding of her love function only prepares disappointment to the man who has saved up all his desire for her; mentally she is still dependent upon her parents whose authority has succeeded in repressing her sexual instincts; she will prove a frigid wife, an attitude which precludes any real sexual gratification on the part of her husband.

I do not know whether the type of frigid woman exists outside of the civilized races; it may exist there; our system of education,

however, is well adapted to the production of that type and these women who conceive without any joy show very little willingness to submit to frequent and painful motherhood.

The very preparation for marriage defeats the ends of marriage; when woman finally surmounts victoriously the difficulties placed in her way by her retarded development, and reaches the height of her femininity and her full capacity for loving, her relations with her husband have long ceased to be agreeable; the only reward for her submission to ethical standards is either ungratified longing, or infidelity or neuroses.

A man's attitude in sexual matters often moulds his attitude towards other life matters. When a man goes forth energetically to conquer the object of his sexual desires we can expect from him the same amount of ruthless energy in his pursuit of other objects. The man who can be deterred from seeking the gratification of his sexual instincts

by too many considerations, will on every occasion show a conciliatory and resigned spirit rather than self assertion.

The moulding influence which the sexual life exerts on the other functions is well illustrated by women's attitude to life. Their education forbids them to apply their minds to sex problems, for which they feel, however, the greatest curiosity; it terrorizes them by telling them that such a curiosity is unwomanly and evidence of sinful propensities. Being forbidden to think of those matters they hold all knowledge of them worthless. The ban placed on thinking reacts upon the sexual sphere, partly on account of the dovetailing of all human functions and partly in an automatic way, just as the ban placed on criticism of a creed reacts upon the faithful, or the dictates of loyalty upon obedient subjects.

I do not believe that the biological contrast between intellectual work and sexual activity explains, as Moebius stated in his much mooted work "The Physiological

Weakmindedness of Woman." I think, on the contrary, that the indubitable fact of woman's intellectual inferiority is to be traced to the mental restraints placed upon her in order to repress her sexual instincts.

In discussing abstinence too little care is generally taken to draw a distinction between the two varieties of abstinence, abstinence from all sexual activity altogether and abstinence from sexual intercourse with the opposite sex. Many people who pride themselves upon having remained abstinent only obtained that result with the help of masturbation and other means of gratification related to the autoerotic sexual activities of infancy. ✓

It is precisely the direct relation between these substitute forms of sexual gratification and infantile sexuality which make substitutes harmful; they predispose the subject to the many varieties of psychoses and neuroses which reveal a return of sexuality to its infantile forms. Masturbation doesn't accord

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✓ in any way with the ideal demands of civilized sexual morality and does not save the young people from the conflicts with the educational ideals which they were anxious to avoid through abstinence. Masturbation also spoils the character in many ways; it accustoms one to pursue important aims without any exertions, and to follow the line of least resistance instead of fighting for success with all the energy at his command; this is an instance of the sexual preformation of character; secondly, the fancies which accompany the gratification endow the object of the sexual desire with a perfection which is seldom met with in reality. A witty writer (K. Krause in the Vienna "Fackel") turned the tables on those who condemn the practice of masturbation and let the truth out in the cynical statement that "coitus is only a meager substitute for masturbation."

Owing to the severity of the cultural demands and the difficulty of preserving abstinence, abstinence has come to mean essential-

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ly that the genitals of opposite sexes are to be kept separated; other forms of sexual activity which are a sort of half compliance with the demands of civilization have been thus fostered and encouraged.

As normal sexual intercourse is forbidden not only by morality but, owing to the possibilities of infection, by hygiene as well, other forms of intercourse, designated as perverse, and in which other parts of the body are taking the place of the genitals, have assumed a decided social importance. Those perversions, however, are not as harmless as certain normal excesses between lovers; they are ethically reprehensible for they transform a serious matter, the love relations of two human beings, into a mere form of play devoid of danger but also bereft of all psychic interest.

Another consequence of all the difficulties that beset the normal sexual life, is the spread of homosexual gratification; to the number of those who were not constitutionally homosexual or became such in childhood we must

now add those who in later life, unable to use the main avenues of sexual gratification were forced into the side street of homosexuality.

These unavoidable and unforeseen consequences of the abstinence movement have one common result, they unfit the individual for married life which according to the intention of "civilized" sexual morality was to be the only beneficiary of all the sexual impulses.

All men who have indulged in masturbation or other perverse sexual practices, that is have gratified their libido under abnormal conditions and in abnormal situations, enter marriage with a diminished vitality. The women who could only preserve their virginity by resorting to similar practices show themselves frigid in matrimonial intercourse. A marriage entered into when the contracting parties suffer from a diminished capacity for love will break up quicker than any other form of union. The man's low virility fails to satisfy the wife's desires; the wife in whom education has developed a disposition

to frigidity, which might, however, have yielded to powerful sexual stimulation, remains totally indifferent. Such a couple encounters more difficulties than a normal couple would, in trying to prevent conception, *for the man's lack of strength does not make it convenient for him to use preenceptives.* Under such unfavorable circumstances intercourse which only appears to be a source of unpleasantness is finally given up and thereupon the marriage loses its *raison d'être*.

Experts will testify that I am not exaggerating and that I am only describing conditions which can be observed in multitudes of cases.

It is hard for the uninitiated to believe what a small proportion of men there are in possession of their full virility and how many frigid women there are, tyrannized upon as they all are by the modern cultural standards, what renunciation marriage entails sometimes for both husband and wife, and to what slight

extent marriage vouchsafes the happiness so ardently longed for.

I previously mentioned that under such circumstances, the next step was a neurosis; I will now add a few remarks on the consequences of such a union for the children, I mean the only child or the very few children, it brings into the world. We may think those children affected by hereditary influences, but on closer inspection we observe that their condition is the result of deep impressions received in infancy.

The neurotic mother, unsatisfied by her husband, lavishes tenderness and care upon her child and awakens in him a premature sexual maturity; the misunderstanding between the parents arouses the child's feelings, and causes it to experience very deeply love, hate and jealousy at the tenderest age. And then a severe training which does not permit of the exercise of the sexual instincts, aroused so early in life, acts as a repressive agent; such a conflict at that age embraces all the

factors that are necessary to bring about chronic nervousness.

I repeat the statement I made above to the effect that in discussing neuroses one generally fails to estimate properly their absolute importance. I do not mean the way in which symptoms are minimized by the patient's relatives who simply disregard them or the family physician's gratuitous assertion that a few weeks hydrotherapeutic treatment, or a few months rest will remove the condition. All that is mere guess work on the part of laymen or ill-informed physicians, idle talk destined to give the patient temporary comfort. We know, however, that a chronic neurosis, even if it does not present any danger to life, constitutes a serious life taint, something like tuberculosis or cardiac disease.

Neuroses would not be so baneful if they only debarred a few weaklings from cooperating in the work of civilization and allowed the others to take part in it at the price possibly of a subjective annoyance; but I

must lay stress on the fact that a neurosis, whatever its degree may be and whomsoever it may affect, can set at naught the plans of civilization and thus enable the repressed antisocial instincts to make their influence felt. And thus our present society cannot even register gains made at a high cost; it gains nothing whatever when it pays for mankind's submission to its extensive code of morals with an increase in neurosis.

Let us take for instance the case observed so frequently of a woman who does not love her husband because owing to the conditions of her union and to her matrimonial experience she has absolutely no reason for loving him; she would like to love him, however, because that is in accord with what she has been brought up to consider as the ideal of married life. She will accordingly suppress all the instincts that would reveal the truth and counteract her ideal endeavor; she will take special care to act like a loving, tender and thoughtful wife. Neurotic troubles will

soon follow upon that attempt at self-repression; a neurosis will soon avenge her upon the unloved husband and cause him just as much unpleasantness and sorrow as the real truth would have caused him had he known it.

This example is very characteristic of the process of neurosis.

We observe the same vicious form of compensation when other instincts, anticultural but not of a directly sexual nature, are being suppressed. People who make powerful attempts at repressing their constitutional tendency to harshness and cruelty and become apparently ultra-good often lose so much of their energy that they cannot fulfill all the duties which correspond to their compensation instincts and do even less good than they would have done if none of their instincts had been repressed.

We may rest assured that to the repression of sexual activity in a race there corresponds an increase in the anxiety about life and the

anxiety about death; this mars the individual's enjoyment and diminishes his willingness to risk his life for the sake of any aim or to bring forth children; it tends to disbar the race or the human group thus affected from a share in the future.

We may well ask the following question: Is our "civilized" sexual morality worth the sacrifice it imposes upon us, especially when one has not freed himself completely enough of hedonism not to include a certain measure of individual gratification among the aims of civilization?

It is not a physician's province to come forward with reform schemes; I thought, however, I could confirm the imperative necessity of reform in this direction by showing the damage caused by our "civilized" sexual morality and pointing out the part it plays in the spreading of nervous disorders in modern times.

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